



Self-Reflection: Go deeper into dashboards



Activity Overview

Previously, you were introduced to the data management tool known as a dashboard. In this self-reflection, you'll examine different kinds of dashboards and consider how they are used by data analysts and their employers.

As a refresher, a dashboard is a single point of access for managing a business's information. It allows analysts to pull key information from data in a quick review by visualizing the data in a way that makes findings easy to understand.

This self-reflection will help you develop insights into your own learning and prepare you to connect your knowledge of dashboards to what you know about business needs. As you answer questions—and come up with questions of your own—you will consider concepts, practices, and principles to help refine your understanding and reinforce your learning. You've done the hard work, so make sure to get the most out of it: This reflection will help your knowledge stick!

Types of dashboards

For a refresher, consider the different types of dashboards a business may use. Often, businesses will tailor a dashboard for a specific purpose. The three most common categories are:

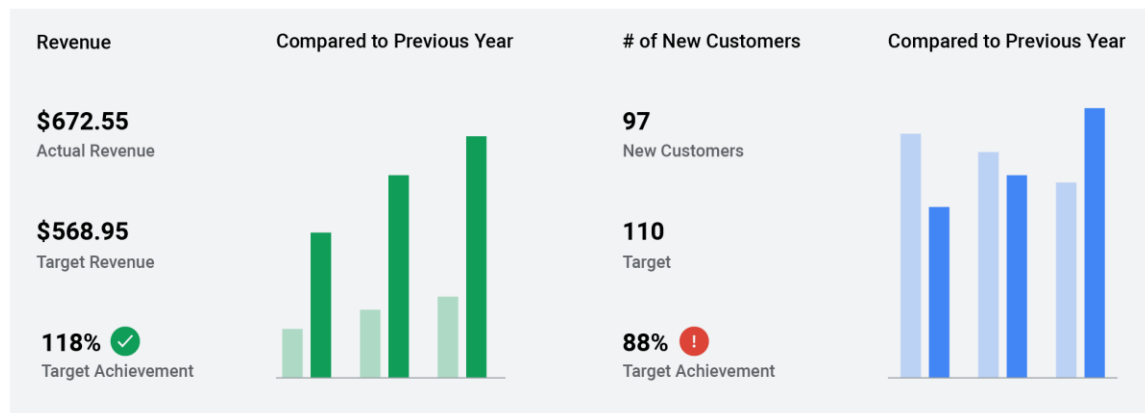
- **Strategic:** focuses on long term goals and strategies at the highest level of metrics
- **Operational:** short-term performance tracking and intermediate goals
- **Analytical:** consists of the datasets and the mathematics used in these sets

Strategic dashboards

A wide range of businesses use strategic dashboards when evaluating and aligning their strategic goals. These dashboards provide information over the longest time frame—from a single financial quarter to years.

They typically contain information that is useful for enterprise-wide decision-making. Below is an example of a strategic dashboard which focuses on key performance indicators (KPIs) over a year.

Revenue and Customer Overview - Q1

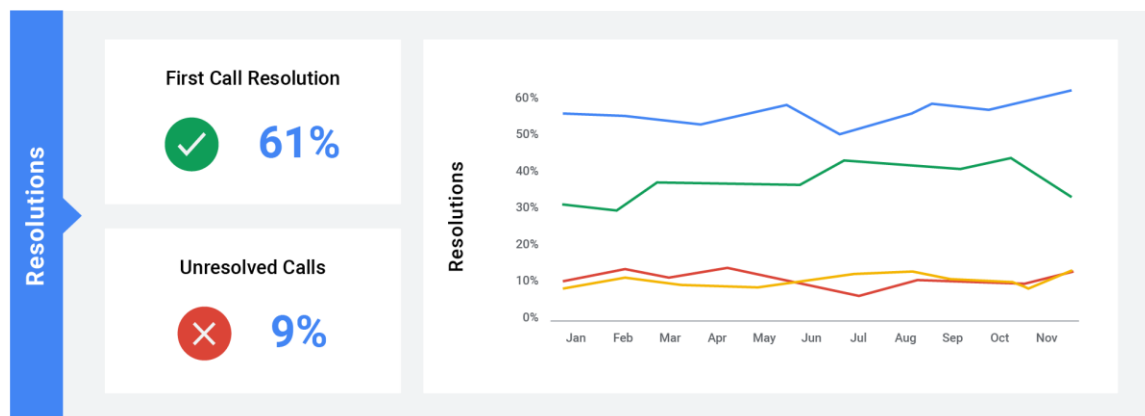


Operational dashboards

Operational dashboards are, arguably, the most common type of dashboard. Because these dashboards contain information on a time scale of days, weeks, or months, they can provide performance insight almost in real-time.

This allows businesses to track and maintain their immediate operational processes in light of their strategic goals. The operational dashboard below focuses on customer service.

Customer Service Team Dashboard

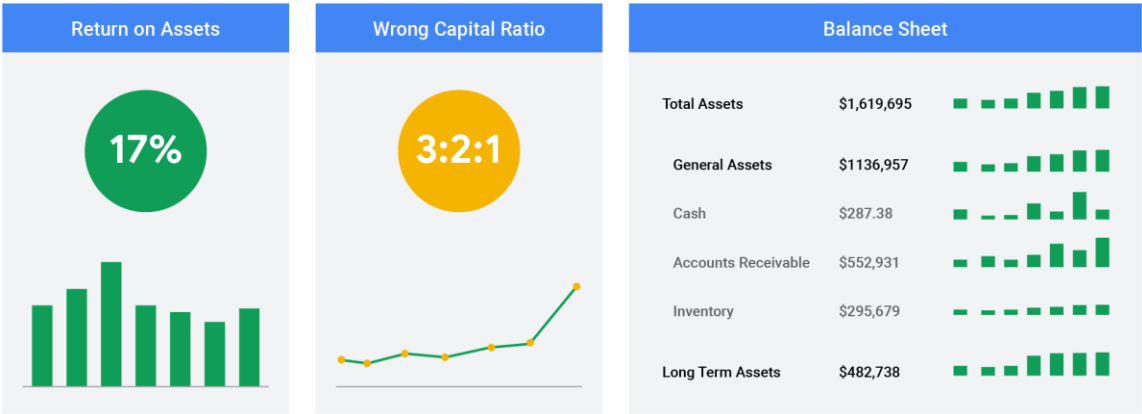


Analytical dashboards

Analytic dashboards contain a vast amount of data used by data analysts. These dashboards contain the details involved in the usage, analysis, and predictions made by data scientists.

Certainly the most technical category, analytic dashboards are usually created and maintained by data science teams and rarely shared with upper management as they can be very difficult to understand. The analytic dashboard below focuses on metrics for a company’s financial performance.

Financial Performance Dashboard



Question 1

Reflection

Consider the different types of dashboards:

- How are the different types of dashboards similar to each other?
- In what ways do they differ?

Write 2-3 sentences (40-60 words) in response to each of these questions. Enter your response in the text box below.

Answer:

- The different types of dashboards are similar to each other because each of them is a powerful visual tool that helps to tell the data story. All dashboards monitor live incoming data. All dashboards track, analyze, and visualize data in order.
- In the strategic dashboard, provide information over the longest time frame; here, revenue and customer overview chart metrics are taken from the previous year. So, a strategic dashboard is different from others. Operational dashboards provide information on a time scale of days, weeks, or months. Here, in the customer service team dashboards, the focus is on the month. So, it differs from others. An analytical dashboard contains a vast amount of data; it is the more technical and analytical dashboard maintained by the data science team. Here in financial performance dashboards, different types of metrics are taken, just like Total assets, General assets, etc., which are different from other dashboards.

Correct

Great work reinforcing your learning with a thoughtful self-reflection! A few commonalities in these examples include:

- **Dashboards are visualizations: Visualizing data can be enormously useful for understanding and demonstrating what the data really means.**
- **Dashboards identify metrics: Relevant metrics may help analysts assess company performance.**

Some differences include the timeframe described in each dashboard. The operational dashboard has a timeframe of days and weeks, while the strategic dashboard displays the entire year. The analytic dashboard skips a specific timeframe. Instead, it identifies and tracks the various KPIs that may be used to assess strategic and operational goals.

Question 2

Now that you have considered the different types of dashboards, think about the impact that dashboards can have on a company:

- What is an example of a data source a company might use with a dashboard?
- How would a company benefit from a dashboard that uses this data?
- What industries or businesses might benefit from using dashboards more than others?

Now, write 2-3 sentences (40-60 words) in response to each of these questions. Enter your response in the text box below.

Answer:

- Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel is an example of a data source a company might use with a dashboard.
- Dashboards benefit for data centralization, visualization, insightfulness, and customization.
- Any industries or business might benefit from using dashboards to find patterns and the path of the project inside data more than others who didn't create dashboards.

Correct

Thank you for your response! Dashboards can help companies perform many helpful tasks, such as:

- Track historical and current performance.
- Establish both long-term and/or short-term goals.
- Define key performance indicators or metrics.
- Identify potential issues or points of inefficiency.

While almost every company can benefit in some way from using a dashboard, larger companies and companies with a wider range of products or services will likely benefit more. Companies operating in **volatile**, or **swiftly** changing markets like marketing, sales, and tech also tend to more quickly gain insights and make data-informed decisions.